

THE ORIGINS AND
DEVELOPMENT
OF THE
ENGLISH
LANGUAGE

Sixth Edition

JOHN ALGEO

THE ORIGINS AND DEVELOPMENT OF THE ENGLISH LANGUAGE

SIXTH EDITION

John Algeo

Based on the original work of

Thomas Pyles



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For a while the word continued to be pronounced without the *l*, riming with *ought* and *thought* in seventeenth-century poetry. In Dr. Johnson's day there was wavering between the older *l*-less and the newer pronunciation with *l*, as Johnson himself testifies in the *Dictionary*. The eighteenth-century **orthoepists** indicated the same wavering. They were men who conceived of themselves as exercising a directive function; they recommended and condemned, usually on quite irrelevant grounds. Seldom were they content merely to record variant pronunciations. Thomas Sheridan, the distinguished father of a more distinguished son named Richard Brinsley, in his *General Dictionary of the English Language* (1780) decides in favor of the *l*-less pronunciation of *fault*, as does James Elphinston in his *Propriety Ascertained* (1787). Robert Nares in his *Elements of Orthoëpy* (1784) records both pronunciations and makes no attempt to make a choice between them. John Walker in his *Critical Pronouncing Dictionary* (1791) declared that to omit the *l* made a "disgraceful exception," for the word would thus "desert its relation to the Latin *falsitas*." The history of the *l* of *vault* is quite similar.

Although such tinkering with the orthography is one cause of the discrepancy between spelling and pronunciation in Modern English, another and more important one is the change in the pronunciation of the tense vowels that helps to demark Middle from Modern English. This change, the most salient of all phonological developments in the history of English, is called the **Great Vowel Shift**.

THE GREAT VOWEL SHIFT

A comparison of the modern developments in parentheses in the chapter on Old English (87) shows clearly the modern representatives of the Old English long vowels. As has been pointed out, the latter changed only slightly in Middle English: [a:], in Old English written *a*, as in *stān*, was rounded except in the Northern dialect to [ɔ:], in Middle English written *o(o)*, as in *stoon*. But this was really the only noteworthy change in quality. By the early Modern English period, however, all the long vowels had shifted: Middle English *ē*, as in *sweete* 'sweet,' had already acquired the value [i] that it currently has, and the others were well on their way to acquiring the values that they have in current English. The changes in the long vowels are summarized in the following table:

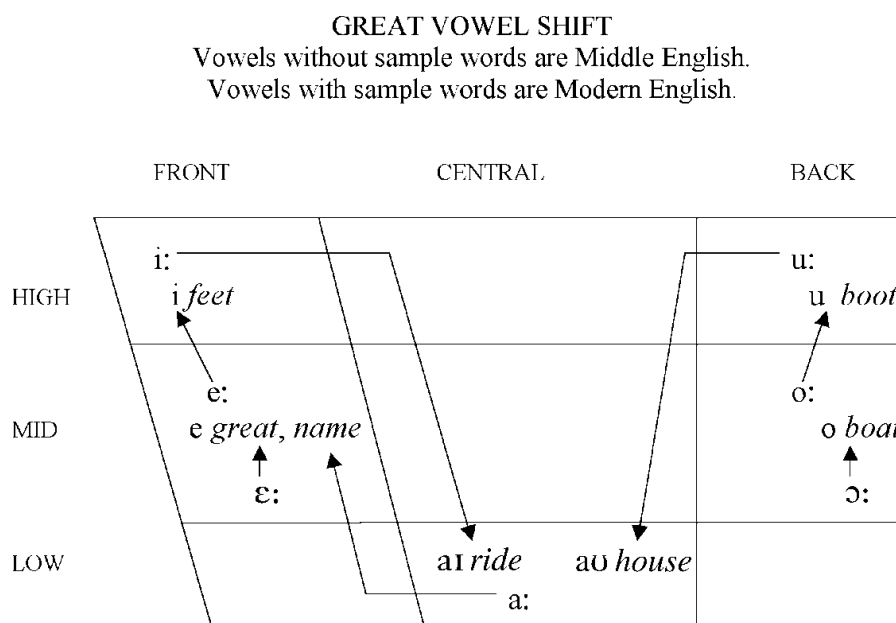
LONG VOWELS

Late Middle English		Early Modern English		Later English	
[a:] name	→	[æ:]	→	[ɛ:]	→ [e] name
[ɛ:] feet	→	[i]	→		feet
[ɛ:] greet	→	[e]	→		great
[i:] ride	→	[ɔ]	→	[aɪ]	ride
[o:] boote	→	[u]	→		boot
[ɔ:] boot	→	[o]	→		boat
[u:] hous	→	[əʊ]	→	[aʊ]	house

In phonological terms:

1. The Middle English high vowels [i:] and [u:] were diphthongized, and then the vowels were centralized and lowered in two steps, first to [əi] and [əu], then to [aɪ] and [aʊ].
2. Each of the Middle English mid vowels was raised one step—higher mid [e:] and [o:] to [i] and [u], respectively, and then lower mid [ɛ:] and [ɔ:] to [e] and [o], respectively.
3. The low vowel [a:] was fronted to [æ:] and then raised in two steps through [ɛ:] to [e].

In early Modern English, vowel quality generally became more important than quantity, so length is shown with early Modern vowels only for [æ:] and [ɛ:], which alone were distinguished from short vowels primarily by length. The beginning and ending points of the shift can also be displayed diagrammatically as in the accompanying chart.



The stages by which the shift occurred and the cause of it are unknown. There are several theories, but as the evidence is ambiguous, they are best left to more specialized study. By some series of intermediate changes, long *rī*, as in Middle English *rīden* ‘to ride,’ became a diphthong [əi]. This pronunciation survives in certain types of speech, particularly before voiceless consonants. It went on in most types of English to become in the course of the seventeenth century [aɪ], though there are variations in pronunciation.

It was similar with Middle English long *ū*, as in *hous* ‘house’: it became [əu]. This [əu], surviving in eastern Virginia and in some types of Canadian English, became [aʊ] at about the same time as [əi] became [aɪ].

Middle English [o:], as in *ro(o)te* ‘root,’ became [u]. Laxing of this [u] to [ʊ] has occurred in *book, foot, good, look, took*, and other words; in *blood* and *flood* there has also been unrounding, resulting in [ə] in these two words. The chronology of this subsequent laxing and unrounding is difficult to establish, as is the distribution of the

various developments. As Helge Kökeritz (*Shakespeare's Pronunciation* 236) points out, Shakespeare's riming of words that had Middle English long close *ō* gives no clue to his pronunciation, for he rimes *food* with *good* and *flood*, *mood* with *blood*, *reprove* with *love* and *dove*. If these are not merely traditional rimes, we must conclude that the distribution of [u], [ʊ], and [ə] was not in early Modern English the same as it is in current English, and there is indeed ample evidence that colloquial English did vacillate a good deal. This fact is not particularly surprising when we remember that there is at the present time a certain amount of wavering between [u] and [ʊ] in such words as *roof*, *broom*, *room*, *root*, and a few others.

The development of Middle English [ɔ:] is straightforwardly to [o] as in Modern English *home* and *stone*. However, in a few words this [ɔ:] was laxed perhaps before the Great Vowel Shift could affect it—for instance, in *hot*, from Middle English *hɔ(ɔ)t*.

Middle English *ā* as in *name* and *ai* as in *nail* had by the early fifteenth century been leveled as [a:] and thus were affected alike by the Great Vowel Shift. The resultant homophony of *tale* and *tail* provided Shakespeare and his contemporaries with what seems to have been an almost irresistible temptation to make off-color puns (for instance, in *The Two Gentlemen of Verona* 2.3.52ff and *Othello* 3.1.6ff). The current pronunciation of such words—that is, with [e]—became normal in standard English probably by the early years of the eighteenth century. All these pronunciations may have existed side by side, however, just as **retarded** and **advanced pronunciations** coexist in current English.

The development of Middle English [e:] to Modern English [i] as in *three* and *kene* 'keen' is quite regular.

The development of Middle English [ɛ:], as in *heeth* 'heath' and other such words, however, is complex. It has two results in early Modern English because of a change that seems to have occurred in late Middle English before the Great Vowel Shift operated. According to the Great Vowel Shift [ɛ:] becomes [e]; and that change is illustrated by Falstaff's *raisin–reason* pun of 1598, in the passage cited at the end of this chapter, and many other such puns—for example, *abased–a beast*, *grace–grease*. (The fullest treatment of Shakespeare's puns—sometimes childish, but frequently richly obscene—is in Part 2 of Kökeritz's *Shakespeare's Pronunciation*.)

But there is also convincing evidence that in late Middle English times, before the Great Vowel Shift occurred, the vowel [ɛ:] also came to exist as a dialect variant in words like *heath*, *beast*, and *grease*. Its precise history is unknown, but it may have developed as a pre-Great Vowel Shift raising in some variety of Middle English. So in late Middle English times, the *heath*, *beast*, and *grease* words could be pronounced in either of two ways—with [ɛ:] or with [e:]. Chaucer sometimes rimes historically close *e* words with words that ordinarily had open *e* in his type of English, indicating his familiarity with such a pre-1400 raising of [ɛ:] to [e:].

When the Great Vowel Shift occurred, it raised [ɛ:] to [e] and also [e:] to [i] in both ways of pronouncing the *heath*, *beast*, and *grease* words. So in early Modern English those words also had two pronunciations, with either [e] (mainly by fashionable people) or with [i] by the less fashionable. And that social difference lasted until the eighteenth century. But fashions change. And during the eighteenth century, the unfashionable pronunciation of the *heath*, *beast*, and *grease* words with [i] became fashionable, except in a few old-fashioned holdouts: *break*, *great*, *steak*, and *yea*. The present [i] vowel in such words as *heath*, *beast*, and *grease* is thus obviously, as H. C. Wyld (211) puts it, "merely the result of the abandonment of one type of pronunciation and the adoption of

another.” Other authorities agree with Wyld’s view—for instance, Kökeritz (*Shakespeare’s Pronunciation* 194–209) and E. J. Dobson (2:606–16).

Before that change in fashion, many rimes from the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries testify to the [e] pronunciation in words that today have [i] instead—for instance, Jonathan Swift’s “You’d swear that so divine a creature / Felt no necessities of nature” (“Strephon and Chloe”), in which the riming words are to be pronounced [kretər] and [netər], and “You spoke a word began with H. / And I know whom you meant to teach” (“The Journal of a Modern Lady”), in which the riming words are [eč] and [teč].

The formerly standard and fashionable pronunciation with [e] survives today only in the handful of words mentioned above (*break*, *great*, *steak*, and *yea*) and in some dialects, such as Irish. A few surnames borne by families long associated with Ireland, like *Yeats* (compare *Keats*), *Re(a)gan*, and *Shea*, have also retained the pronunciation with [e], as does *Beatty* in American speech.

As Dobson (2:611) points out, “Throughout the [early] ModE period there was a struggle going on between two ways of pronouncing ‘ME ē words’”; ultimately the [i] pronunciation was to win out, so that only a few words remain as evidence of the [e] sound that prevailed in fashionable circles from about 1600 until the mid-eighteenth century. This process was gradual, as the fashion spread from one word to another.

OTHER VOWELS

STRESSED SHORT VOWELS

The stressed short vowels have remained relatively stable throughout the history of English. The most obvious changes affect Middle English short *a*, which shifted by way of [a] to [æ], and Middle English short *u*, which was unrounded and shifted to [ə], though its older value survives in a good many words in which the vowel was preceded by a labial consonant, especially if it was followed by *l*—for instance, *bull*, *full*, *pull*, *bush*, *push*, and *put* (but compare the variant *putt*).

It is evident that there was an unrounded variant of short *o*, reflected in spellings of the late sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. Wyld (240–1) cites a number of examples of *a* for *o* in spellings, including Queen Elizabeth I’s “I pray you stap the mouthes.” This unrounding did not affect the language as a whole, but such doublets as *strop*–*strap* and *god*–*gad* remain to testify to its having occurred. Today [ɑ] is the typical American vowel of most words that had short [ɔ] in Middle English (*god*, *stop*, *clock*, and so forth). Short *e* has not changed, except occasionally before [ŋ], as in *string* and *wing* from Middle English *streng* and *wenge*, and short *i* remains what it has been since Germanic times.

SHORT VOWELS

Late Middle English	Early Modern English	Later English
[a] that	→ [æ]	→
[ɛ] bed	→	→
[ɪ] in	→	→
[ɔ] on, odd	→	[ɔ] or [ɑ]
[u] but	→ [ə]	→